

Zerado – Voice & Tone Working Guide

The full standard is `brand-manual.md` §8. This is the pocket version, with the situations that actually came up while writing the landing page.

The three words, and what they are not

We are	We are not
Dry — the fact is the point	Sarcastic, or bubbly
Concrete — numbers, names, specifics	Vague, or jargon-padded
Confident — direct, no hedging	Boastful, or timid

The audience is people who live in a terminal. They have a finely-tuned detector for marketing language, they will forgive niche, and they will not forgive hype.

Do / don't, drawn from real Zerado situations

1 • Describing what the product does

- ✗ "Experience the power of a next-generation, blazing-fast CLI-first gaming ecosystem."
- ✓ "It's a text program. It starts instantly, works offline, and your library is one file you own."
- Three verifiable claims beat six adjectives. This audience checks.

2 • A price is in budget but above its historical low

- ✗ "🔥 This game is a STEAL at \$15! Grab it before it's gone!"
- ✓ "\$15, and in budget. It's been \$8. Maybe wait."
- Zerado's actual value proposition here is telling you *not* to buy. Fake urgency destroys the trust the whole feature depends on.

3 • Marking a game finished

- ✗ "Congratulations on this incredible achievement! You're a true champion!"
- ✓ "Zerado. 41 hours. Sixth this year."
- The moment carries itself. Three facts land harder than an exclamation mark.

4 • Nothing is downloadable yet (the whole page is pre-launch)

- ✗ "Try Zerado today — download now!"
- ✓ "Nothing to install yet. Tell us you're in, and we'll tell you when there is."
- Say what stage the product is actually at. A waitlist framed honestly reads as early, not as broken.

5 • The community layer costs money later

- ✗ "We're SO excited to announce our amazing new social features — coming soon!"
- ✓ "These run on servers, and servers cost money — so this part will need a premium account or a donation once it exists."
- State the cost before anyone asks. Up front reads as respect; discovered later reads as a catch. And disclosure is not an ask — never follow this sentence with a button.

6 • Steam needs a public profile, and that's a real limitation

- ✗ "Oops! Something went wrong. Please try again later."
- ✓ "Steam only returns a library if the profile is public, or if the key belongs to that same account. If a profile is private, Steam won't share the list — that's a Steam setting, not something Zerado can work around."
- Name what happened, why, and whether it's on us or the reader. "Something went wrong" is the one sentence this audience cannot act on.

7 • A feature that isn't built yet

- ✗ "Powerful recommendations, coming soon!"

- ✓ "Phase 3 — Recommendations & Budget. What to buy, and whether to wait. Planned."
- The roadmap format *is* the honesty mechanism. A phase name, a plain-language line, and a status marker that never says "done" until it is.

8 • Introducing a Portuguese word

- ✗ Leaving *zerado* or *sinopse* unglossed, assuming the reader will infer it.
- ✗ Explaining it more than once — a glossary makes the page read like homework.
- ✓ One clause, at the first appearance, then used plainly ever after: "*zerado* — Portuguese for beaten: finished, cleared, 100%'d."

Words this brand never uses

Banned outright, no exceptions found while writing this page:

- **Hype adjectives:** revolutionary, seamless, unleash, game-changing, next-generation, cutting-edge, blazing-fast, powerful (as a standalone claim), amazing, incredible.
- **Exclamation marks.** No situation in this product needs one — not a sync, not a purchase verdict, not a *zerado*.
- **Emoji in product copy.** State is carried by colour + glyph + label (brand-manual §4.3); emoji carry nothing and undercut that system.
- **"Gamer."** Never used to describe the reader.
- **Filler openers:** "In today's fast-paced world," "As we all know," "It's no secret that," "Now more than ever." Every one wastes the most valuable line on the page.
- **Vague quantities.** "A lot of hours," "tons of games," "many players." Say the number, or cut the claim.
- **Thesaurus-inflation.** "Utilize" for use, "leverage" for use, "empower" for help. Plain verbs read as more confident, not less.

The three awkward moments this page has to hold, and how

1 • Nothing to download yet. Say the stage plainly and once, then move on — don't apologise for it repeatedly, and don't bury it. "Nothing to install yet" is a complete sentence; it doesn't need "unfortunately" in front of it or "but soon!" after it.

2 • The community costs money, eventually. State the cost before it's asked. Never attach a button, a price, or a tier name to the statement — there isn't one yet, and inventing one to look more finished is worse than saying "not decided."

3 • Steam needs a public profile. This is a real limitation of a third-party service, not a Zerado bug, and the copy says so directly: name what's required, name why, and stop. Don't soften it with "unfortunately" or oversell the workaround, because there isn't one.

One test that catches most drafts before they ship

Read the sentence back and ask: **could a competitor's marketing team have written this exact sentence?** If yes, it's generic — cut it or replace the adjective with a fact. Every sentence on this page that survived that test is the one doing real work.

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